said. ‘All I have to tell you youngsters is to study well and serve the country.’

I did not give up. After much persuasion, when the great man finally agreed to address the Thyagaraja College students, Chettiar was happy. And I was proud.

Kamaraj won over even his detractors with his simplicity and clarity of thought. What attracted me more to the Congress leader was his sense of empathy, which was at the root of every decision he took as the Chief Minister. For what he had not learned from books—as Annadurai and some other Dravidian party leaders did—Kamaraj imbibed from life experiences.

The now famous mid-day meal scheme in schools was one such initiative. The British had introduced the programme to feed poor children in primary schools of Madras Presidency as early as in 1925, but after Independence thousands of children were out of school because they had to work to support their parents to earn. It was not a sense of history that prompted Kamaraj to reintroduce the scheme in 1962. It was a life event of a school boy called Valluvan that moved Kamaraj to feed the children and keep them in schools.

Providence—some call it coincidence—has played a key role in the making and unmaking of history. Here, it so happened that Valluvan was a sympathetic boy and the son of N D Sundaravadivelu, who was then the director of public instruction and Kamaraj’s advisor on education. Valluvan often went home hungry and sad. When Sundaravadivelu asked him the reason, the boy said he was giving away his lunch to students who could not afford a morsel and hence were irregular to school. Sundaravadivelu reported this to Kamaraj who immediately ordered the mid-day meal scheme. It became a benchmark for several other Indian states and a reference point for international agencies dealing with nutrition and education.

While student activities on the campus instilled in us a sense of societal commitment, a crop of outstanding teachers made academics gruelling and rewarding. I owe much more than my engineering skills to six professors—V Subbaraman, C Kothandaraman, P L Meiyappan, Krishnan, Maria Loius